
A TOPOGRAPHICAL ACCOUNT
OF
MARKET LAVINGTON.

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Reminiscences.

A
TOPOGRAPHICAL ACCOUNT
OF
MARKET LAVINGTON,
WILTS,

ITS PAST AND PRESENT CONDITION.

ALSO, THE RISE AND PROGRESS OF
THE INDEPENDENT CHURCH
IN THAT PLACE.

AND
THE AUTHENTIC HISTORY OF DAVID SAUNDERS,
THE
Pious Shepherd of Salisbury Plain.

WITH ILLUSTRATIONS.

BY THE REV. H. ATLEY,

AUTHOR OF "DRUIDICAL ANTIQUITIES," "FAMILIAR SCENES,"
"HAPPY JAMES," ETC., ETC.

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INTRODUCTION.

NEVER in the history of this country has literature assumed so prominent a position as it does at the present time; not in one department only, but in the ample circle she travels, each presenting its own peculiar claims to attention and regard, thus catering to the diversified necessities of the human family.

Among the various intellectual viands, none is more generally acceptable than History; and simply for this reason, in other departments or productions of the pen we have abstract principles and theories, which require to be worked out by mental or manual processes ere they assume a form to be capable of appreciation by the general mind. In History truths are progressively elaborated and developed under the immediate influence of time and circumstances, by which their qualities become known, and their value tested and proved.

In the first class we may be said to have presented to us a subtle spirit so ethereal and liable to evaporation as to be difficult of retention to any important purpose, and so versatile as to be susceptible of any form at the will of the operator; in the latter we possess a definite tangible reality, in which we see reflected as in a mirror the principles, feelings, motives, and results, not only of the several actors, but of the times in which they lived, all which become fixed or Daguerreotyped for the benefit of those that come after.

The term History is of a general and extensive character, admitting of a very minute subdivision. In the first place it may be simple or compound, pure or mixed, as it embraces persons, times, or things, taken singly or in their combination in the mutual influence they exert. This is the general form in which it is presented. In the next place, it may range as universal, national, provincial, local, or individual. Another division will give us civil, political, ecclesiastical: each of these have their intrinsic value, will materially influence the progress of civilisation, and promote the well-being of society;

but to the last, viz., ecclesiastical, there belongs a charm pre-eminently its own, as it closely approximates to eternity.

The following History is of the mixed class, as the Table of Contents will show, so that it is hoped, while it may possess or create a general interest, its specific features will please others; and its ecclesiastical lineaments afford to the devout mind great gratification.

The Author craves the indulgence of his readers, and hopes his efforts will receive a general verdict of approbation.

SECTION I.

Etymology of the place—Its situation—Geological characters—
Antiquity—Architectural features—Traditions—Commercial status.

EAST, or as it is sometimes denominated, MARKET LAVINGTON, distant from London 89 miles, is situated about the middle, rather inclining to the western, part of the county of Wiltshire, on the north side of the extensive downs celebrated for the relics of a barbaric age, when human victims were supposed to appease the anger of the gods, of which a distant view is obtained on the road from Salisbury, near the Bustard Inn, so called from a bird once found on this plain. It graced the table of the new Mayor of Salisbury in former times on the day of his election to the civic office; but is now obsolete. The hunting of this bird once constituted a chief amusement to the neighbouring gentry. Lavington runs in a north-easterly direction, forming a portion of the celebrated Vale of Pewsey, reckoned the best and most fertile part of the county.

The etymology of this place like that of many others has probably suffered by local corruptions, it is either of Saxon or Norman origin—a word compounded of two others, *Lav* or *Lave* and *ton*. The former might describe its position, the latter its quality or nature.

The names of places are frequently very descriptive of their situation, as Wilton, near Salisbury, or, as it known in ancient records, Willytown—the town on the Willy, a river running through it to Salisbury, where it unites with other streams, and flows into the English Channel at Christchurch. We propose to take this as our guide on the present occasion, and establish our hypothesis by several concurrent facts.

The term *Lav* or *Lave* may either mean watered—washed, left, or hidden; and the termination *ton*, which is a very general one, a town, as Easterton, Littleton, Maddington, and Shrewton.

Situated as Lavington is at the foot of the downs, which rise to a considerable altitude above it, with hills on the opposite side of nearly equal height, seen from either it appears to lie in a complete basin, every way adapted to act as a drain or receiver of water from the uplands—a fact illustrated in the years 1841–2, when a great destruction of property—took place at Shrewton, through inundations occasioned by the accumulation of water by the rapid thawing of the snow in various natural basins in the vicinity, as at Candown Bottom and other places. The soil of the valley, so favourable to the cultivation of edible roots, being marked by the combined characters of the surrounding barriers.

In some parts of the kingdom there are places where well-defined and specific geological features conduct to certain conclusions, such as the primeval deposits of virgin soil—the annual product of rank foliage where the foot of man for ages never trod, which, when brought to tillage, yields successive crops of abundance—the subsidence of a vast and overwhelming inundation—the retreat of the watery element after ages of possession, leaving its hitherto submerged bed high and dry. As an illustration, we may refer to the subsoil of Bath, which is stone of so friable a nature as to be easily affected by the elements, and, if examined, will be found a combination of various shells, which plainly tell its former state, or the severance of some great and terrible convulsion, forming vast chasms, and exhibiting the various strata of rocks far down in the womb of the earth. There is a very good display of this at villas in the neighbourhood of Frome, Somersetshire, and at Clifton Hotwells, near Bristol, or in places round the Isle of Wight, and in the coal-fields at Radstock, and each of these present their own peculiar characters; but here we have on either side of the valley a separate and distinct formation. The downs predominate in chalk, on a stony brackish soil, with but a thin layer of vegetable earth on a substratum of flint and gravel; the exception of the hollows no way interfering with the general state. On the opposite side there is sand to the depth of several feet resting upon sandstone, with occasional layers of granite, then again sand and sandstone, ultimating in a subsoil of granite, and this extends for several miles. The washings of the two barriers by the repeated rains, together with the humid atmosphere, so striking a character in the climate of this country, combining in various degrees, produces the fertile soil of the valley from the sandy loam to the stiff clay.

If we recur to the times of invasion when hordes of barbarians sought the subjugation of this island, the predatory warfare with the ravages to which the inland parts of the country were exposed, there would naturally be a disposition and desire of secrecy and seclusion. Now no place could be better adapted for this purpose, surrounded as it is by the uplands before referred to, lying, too, at a distance from the main road on either hand, and possessing within itself the chief resources of subsistence, it could remain unknown as long as needful. We must remember, when speaking of by-gone times their facilities of information were very rude and simple. How, in the absence of the appliances of transit and intercommunication which we possess, they would denote the direction of various towns we know not; their proximity to certain well known objects, or as occupying particular situations, might afford them means and facilities, especially if we allow the progress of improvement. Let us apply this theory in the present case, and it might be the town left on quitting the downs, and emerging towards the chief towns, as Bath, or the last town prior to ascending them. The name, therefore might mean the washed or watered—the hidden or left town.

As but very few of the older buildings remain, and what traditions there are being very vague, it is impossible to fix the date of its formation. The church, of which we shall speak more fully elsewhere, has doubtless stood for some hundreds of years. The old parsonage, with its gables and cress-muntained windows, carries the visitor into by-gone times. A large mansion on the road to Urchfont, at the turn to Eastcott, has undoubtedly the marks of age; its ponderous appearance, numerous gables, heavy stacks of chimnies, and ballustraded gallery—tell of times when profuse hospitality was common. There is one at Easterton, of which we have more definite accounts: it is now in the occupation of Mr. Neville. Report states it to have been erected by the Protector, Oliver Cromwell, about the year 1657, for his general, Kinson; and to which he himself oft repaired, either when commanding in the wars between Charles II. and the parliament (of whose armies Cromwell was commander-in-chief), one of which took place at Bratton, about eight miles distant, a spot celebrated from the time of Alfred the Great, where, after rallying his troops at Clay hill, near Frome, he gave the Danes battle and routed them, the spot is shown where the Danes encamped and where Alfred penetrated in the disguise of an harper,—or probably the Protector here sought for seclusion and rest to a mind perturbed

and alarmed to suspicion by the publication of a work, supposed to allude to him, entitled, "Killing no Murder."

At Wroughton's Folly there are remains of a once extensive erection, which, from its size, would have accommodated a numerous family. Its picturesque situation, surrounded with extensive grounds, formed a charming retreat; it was occupied by a retired merchant, but has long gone to decay. Report states the ruins were once the retreat of a daring freebooter, who preyed upon the surrounding homesteads and laid under contribution the yeoman as he returned from the neighbouring markets: little now remains save the foundations of the cellars. Near this spot are three mounds within a small enclosure in the middle of a field, of which tradition thus speaks:—In the time of Charles II., when that dreadful scourge, the plague, which destroyed upwards of one hundred thousand of the inhabitants of London, broke out, three brothers, seeking to avoid the common lot, fled to this spot, thinking thereby to escape, but they were overtaken by the fell destroyer, and buried here.

Lavington was formerly distinguished for its corn market and the manufacture of malt, in which articles business to a very considerable extent was transacted; this gave it the appellative attached. Its proximity to the rising town of Devizes soon reduced it to its present condition; it is now generally known for its large supplies of vegetables to the market of Devizes, distant 6 miles,—Trowbridge, 12 miles,—Bath, 22 miles,—and Salisbury, 19 miles. The market-place continues to maintain its former dimensions, and constitutes the favourite resort of the juvenile portion of the population. The stocks, once a terror and punishment to evildoers, have lost their dread, and the clanking iron has become a musical instrument in their estimation. Near this is the Engine-house, a wooden erection, with a cupulo for a bell whose tongue is happily seldom inclined to speak, the services of the engine is seldom required; fire, as an element of alarm, being of very rare occurrence. The population of the place, including the hamlet of Easterton, is 1700; and the area of the parish about 3036 acres to Lavington, and 1592 to Easterton.

SECTION II.

Ecclesiastical and Denominational accommodation—Literary and other advantages—Educational facilities—Scenery.

THIS place is included within the diocese of Salisbury, and has a church of considerable antiquity, dating somewhere between 1360 and 1380, most probably the time of Edward III. It was built by the Roman Catholics, and dedicated to St. Michael, and is in the gift of Christchurch college, Oxford. Its style of architecture is a mixture; there are some parts appearing older than the main building, which would lead to the supposition of a prior edifice; the striking features denote the time of transition from the plain English to that of the decorated, but some parts are of very recent construction. It consists of a chancel of about 42 ft. by 18½ ft.; a nave, 54 ft. by 51 ft.; and a square tower, 17 ft. by 18 ft.; and will accommodate about 600 people. The chancel, which has been recently renovated, is inlaid with encaustic tiles; and here are several marble monumental tablets to the relics of the Sainburys; one especially with a full-length female figure to Thomas Twice, sheriff, and once Lord Mayor of London; and another to Mr. Merewether, father of the town clerk of the same place. The tower is an embattled one, having a ring of six bells. Beneath it are two or three records of munificence; one a bequest by — Tanner, formerly vicar of this parish, afterwards Bishop of St. Asaph, to the following effect:—To the minister for a sermon annually, £1; for the purchase of four bibles for the use of the poor, £1; for the education of three children, £1; a dinner for the respectable inhabitants, £1; the ringers for two short peals, 6s.; the sexton and clerk, 5s. A gilt tablet to this worthy man is placed in the nave, near the chancel. The other bequest is by two brothers, of £100 each in the consols; the interest to be distributed in bread to the poor. Beneath the tower is a stone font with a carved oak lid, the work of a self-taught artist, a native of Bath; presented to the church by Mr. Stubbart. This edifice is situated at the west end of the place on rising ground, and forms a conspicuous object in all directions.

With this is connected a handsome building for the use of the day school, which is conducted upon the plan of the national system, numbering 90 boys and 75 girls; and a Sabbath school, numbering 180 boys, 170 girls, and 17 teachers.

There is also a respectable Dissenting cause, dating from the year 1801, when a church was formed upon the platform of the Independent or Congregational order. Their place of worship is at the east end of the town; its dimensions are 33 ft. by 42 ft., and it is capable of holding between four and five hundred of this cause: a fuller account will be given in the subsequent pages. They have connected with them a good Sabbath school, numbering 60 boys, 70 girls, and 13 teachers. A British and Foreign day school was established, but various circumstances having militated against its progress and success, it has declined, and is at the present time carried on as a private undertaking. With the Independents is associated a Dorcas Society, consisting of twelve subscribers, a number of whom meet once a month to make garments, which are given away to the poor of the place. There is also a society organised in connection with the Wiltshire Association of the British and Foreign Bible Society for the supply of the Holy Scriptures at cost-price to the poor, and to render aid to the Parent Society. This is confined to no denomination, but embraces all who desire their circulation without note or comment.

Two small Baptist interests of high Calvinistic principles and maintaining close communion, are situated in the lower parts of the town; one in a lane near the weighing engine, and chiefly supplied by lay-agents from the neighbourhood; the congregation exceeds in number one hundred, and there are twenty members; the building measures about 30 ft. by 28 ft.: the other, which is an offshoot, has recently been erected; it is but small, measuring 30 ft. by 20 ft., and is situated in Church Street; the congregation does not exceed one hundred, and has but few members; it has a resident minister.

The Primitive Methodists have for some time laboured here; they formerly had a flourishing society of thirty members, but have declined, owing to the difficulty of obtaining a suitable place; their present number is probably about ten. They form part of the Newbury circuit.

A Temperance Society, established in the year 1838, has been the means of considerable good, reclaiming several persons who were reduced to a state

of poverty and ruin, restoring and elevating them to comfort and respectability. The pledge-book gives the numbers at the present time as 450; they circulate tracts and advance their views by occasionally holding meetings.

Reading-rooms are open for the accommodation of subscribers, where the daily and weekly papers with other works are supplied; and where, during the winter months, lectures are occasionally delivered upon literary and scientific subjects: they are situated in the middle of the town, just below the Market-place.

An Horticultural Society has lately sprung up for encouraging the cultivation of fruits and vegetables. Prizes are awarded to the successful competitors at the annual exhibition, which is held in the grounds of the president, Charles Hitchcock, Esq., at Fiddington. Watson Taylor, Esq., of Urchfont, patron: Mr. H. Gauntlett, secretary. It has 156 members.

The facilities for intercommunication are good. A coach from Salisbury to Chippenham passes through West Lavington, distant one mile, every alternate day, returning the following; and one recently started leaves here for the Hungerford extension line each alternate day in time for the up train, and leaves on its return on the following, upon the arrival of the down train. There is also a daily carrier to Devizes, and two to Salisbury weekly.

A small stream rises at the farther end of Easterton, and supplies the sheet of water in the grounds at Fiddington (where there is a pleasant and comfortable asylum for lunatics),—winds to Northbrook—passes on through the meads at Ladywood to Russell mill, where it joins another stream (which rises at Newlam, a mile from West Lavington; this formerly covered a space of seven acres, but is now reduced to very narrow limits)—united in one it pursues its way towards Bath and Bristol, where it falls into the Avon and Severn. A branch which turns off towards Devizes empties itself into the Avon and Kennet canal; in its progress it forms the moving power to several mills, and imparts fertility to the various meads in its course.

The scenery around is of the most delightful character, the sands or common have been successfully brought into cultivation, and where formerly but few buildings appeared numerous houses have been erected, which bespeak the efforts of the humble classes to attain respectability and comfort; while the

tillage constantly going on gives great animation to the scene. The country around is everywhere well wooded to the north, and may with propriety be termed a panorama, reaching to the vicinity of Bath. From hence and on the downs report states that when the atmosphere is clear, and with the aid of good glasses, the Welsh mountains may be descried. A good eye will be able to discover Lansdown and the Beckford monument, Stourton Tower, and the spire of Salisbury Cathedral. The most favourable points of observation are the downs on the top of Lavington hill, Wroughton's Folly, and Ledgehill, on the road to Bath and Devizes, there are a few spots possessing a romantic feature, exhibiting as they do high walls of strata surmounted with tall waving foliage. Here the lover and copyist of nature might revel in perfect delight, and gather many a sketch for his portfolio. About some 25 years ago the approaches were everywhere impeded by toll-gates, the heavy expenses thereby entailed upon the farmer and gentry led to vigorous efforts for their removal by liberal contributions to a fund for this purpose, they were bought up, and in one day no less than twelve of these impediments were destroyed. The event is annually commemorated by a public dinner at the chief inn and a bonfire in the evening.

There are two or three clubs for the assistance of members in a time of sickness, to afford means of burial, and also to furnish clothing.

SECTION III.

Past religious state—Feeble instrumentality of its reformation—DAVID SAUNDERS, the pious Shepherd of Salisbury Plain—His early life—Correction of error in former narratives.

IN reference to the former religious state of this place the picture is a truly gloomy one—a common ruin of all that is holy seems to have pervaded society from the highest to the lowest; nor did the condition appear to awaken any concern—bull and badger baiting, cock and dog fighting, with all their concomitant evils, depravity of manners, pugilistic encounters, drunkenness and profanity, were the characteristics of the people, not of the lower classes only, but also the middle and upper, and not only sanctioned but encouraged by the clergy; to such an extent did this run, that a notoriety rested upon the place and its inhabitants for miles round. It is true the Society of Friends had long possessed a place of worship here, but little benefit resulted to the morals of the people. The peculiar tenets held by them, together with other circumstances, tended to their decline, public service was confined to periodical assemblings, called quarterly district meetings, the funeral of friends, or the visits of some of their principal speakers.

In the Establishment the teaching was a meagre maudling something, for neither in precept or example could it be called religion, or even morality. Its quality was of the same stamp as that which generally pervaded the discourses of the clergy of that day, and which diffused its baneful seeds over the country at large, such as might be expected, where the sports of the field, the facilities for angling, and the pleasures of good-fellowship were objects of pre-eminent attraction to clerical ambition. The submission of the poor to their superiors; reverence and obedience to the commands of the priesthood; abject veneration for the Established Church; punctuality in attendance on her rites and ceremonies, with a full and prompt discharge of all her dues; these were the staple of her instructions, and all that was

required by her to constitute a good man, a Christian, and to entitle him to heaven; while every effort made to instruct and enlighten the mind received the whole weight of her opposition and anathema, as it was considered far preferable that the population be left in the grossest darkness, perfectly and profoundly ignorant of the claims of God, so besotted in vice were they, that to be the best fighter, to have the best bulldog, to possess the finest game bird, or to have won the prize in any of the sports was the highest felicity and enjoyment their minds could desire or appreciate.

As in many of the most important conveniences and improvements of civilised life, the origin or spring has been insignificant and comparatively obscure, surrounded with every disadvantage and impediment to success; so also has it been with our most valuable religious movements, “For God hath chosen the foolish things of this world to confound the wise; and God hath chosen the weak things of the world to confound the things that are mighty; and base things of the world, and things which are despised, hath God chosen, yea, and things which are not, to bring to nought things that are: that no flesh should glory in his presence.” ^[13] Look at the great moral and spiritual reformation which commenced in the year 1503, when a change took place in Germany, agitating the whole Christian world, shaking the papal kingdom from the centre to the circumference, opening to the light its secret abominations, overturning its iniquitous customs, irradiating its darkest recesses, and pouring its healing waters into the abodes of suffering and woe. And what was the immediate instrument, and who was the artificer selected or raised up to accomplish this? The prohibited volume of the Holy Scripture, which had long lain on the shelves of the library at the Augustine monastery at Erfurt—here Martin Luther, a monk, found it, secretly he conveyed it to his cell, and amid the solemn silence and darkness of night, his solitary lamp tells his employment, and aids him in exploring the mine of truth, the record of eternal life. Celestial light diffused itself through his mind, illumined his soul, and wrought strong convictions that the principles and practices of that Church, of which he was the avowed and sworn servant, were at perfect variance with truth. Arrayed against him as was the whole hierarchy of that apostate Church, he clothed himself in the panoply of the Gospel, especially “the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God,” to do warfare in the sacred cause.

So here an obscure peasant, inhabiting a cot so lowly that those accustomed to more convenient and comfortable accommodation would be disposed to spurn the humble abode as a mere hovel unfit for human dwelling; whose days are devoted to toil amid exposure to all the varying influences of weather, the father of a large and increasing family, whose wants might plead excuse, and claim his undivided attention, together with a heavily afflicted wife, whose ill-health prevents her sharing her husband's labours, or ministering to the comforts of her family, his scanty pittance not exceeding one shilling a-day, save the help derived from friendship's gifts or dole of charity, or what his children (into whose minds he had carefully installed those principles of right and industry) could earn by cow-tending and other casual employment, the younger ones collecting the knobs of wool found in the sheep-walks, which the elder ones would in the evening card, clean, and spin, and either dispose of to persons inclined to purchase, knit into stockings, or send to Potterne or Cheverill villages in the vicinity, where a weaver or two resided, and have it wove into blankets, or flannels for petticoats. Boys and girls would accompany the father, and assist him to keep the sheep from the corn. He it is who is to commence a local reformation, both by his own example and precept, introducing the Gospel, whose divine light and effects are to spread and diffuse themselves around and onward through subsequent years—yes, even into the boundless region of that world of immensity—Eternity.

In the year 1717, in a very mean and humble cottage at Littleton Wells, a hamlet of West Lavington, dwells a man of lowly occupation, a shepherd, DAVID SAUNDERS. Beneath this roof an immortal being commences his career; an event which, when viewed aright, is calculated to awaken thoughts of deep import even when unconnected with any remarkable circumstances, how much more so when results of infinite moment follow. No portentous predictions foreshadow his future course; the probability is that the paternal lot will be his, and peasant toil with poverty's hard crust his only heritage. Infancy and youth in their common every-day occurrences are past, and to him the barest modicum of instruction is afforded probably at the dame school of the village. He learned to read and write, beyond those rudimentary aids he does not advance; the situation his father fills requires his early assistance and help; he becomes an under-shepherd, and mid the variations of heat and cold, rain and snow, wind and sunshine, his frame becomes nerved to life's rough path. He rises to man's estate, and quitting

the subordinate situation takes the head; whether this was before his father's death or after, is not quite certain; it is, however, an authenticated fact he did succeed his father, and remained on the same farm upwards of thirty years, although during that time the property more than once changed hands; it was the same as is now occupied by Mr. Hooper. He married Lydia Bishop, and reared a family of sixteen children. His wife died in the year 1789.

David Saunders, the individual of whom we now speak, or as he is more generally designated on account of his piety, the pious Shepherd of Salisbury Plain, was early brought under the itinerant labours of some of the followers of John Wesley; at what exact period is not known. On one occasion going to hear a Methodist preacher, probably at Imber or Seend, with a young man, one of their society, he complains of a painful and distressing disease, to which from early life he had been subject, which not only caused him great trouble but was regarded by him as a great affliction (the leprosy). His companion, while compassionating his case, took occasion to remind him that he was afflicted with a far worse disease, that not only afflicted his body but ruined both body and soul, making it loathsome in the eyes of a pure and holy God, and entailed upon it eternal misery; recommending him instantly to apply to the great Physician for that balm which alone can effect a perfect cure. Thus made acquainted with the Gospel, he continued the pursuit until he was brought to a full realisation of its power: the sincerity of his profession evidenced itself by the anxiety awakened in his mind with reference to the condition of those around him; for, as was stated at the commencement of this section, the religious state of the neighbourhood was awful and alarming; he was a light in a dark place, and as was said of the church of Pergamos, "Thou dwellest where Satan's seat is." Pains and penalties awaited those who dared to think and act in opposition to the authorised teachers, and to disturb the heavy gloom that rested on the public mind; for at this time the same person held the two livings of East and West Lavington. The statement in the tract published by the Religious Tract Society would lead to the formation of a high estimate of the piety of the neighbourhood and the resident clergy; there is nothing whatever to warrant this, quite the reverse, and would apply to times of a much later date. There is also a very great inaccuracy as to the shepherd being placed in the situation of parish clerk, and removing to the house of his predecessor, where a Sabbath school is reported to have been commenced under the auspices of the vicar and Mr. Johnson, who was no other person than Dr.

Stonehouse, the projector of the Infirmary at Salisbury and the resident surgeon there, but having been unsuccessful in his treatment of a small-pox patient, which affected his reputation and very much depressed him, he quitted the medical profession and took holy orders; the living of the two Cheverills, which were then united, being presented him by Earl Radnor. And it is further stated those individuals established a day school for a few girls to be instructed by the shepherd's wife, who was incapacitated for outdoor employment, being heavily afflicted with the rheumatism. These facts are utterly false; she was chiefly employed in visiting and nursing the sick, being the only person in the parish at that time able to do so: this employment she continued till a short time before her death. It is true the doctor was a great friend to the shepherd and his family; and when down here, which was principally in the winter, he would frequently have him to dine with him at the parsonage as a special mark of his esteem. He gave him a small bible, which is now in the possession of the Rev. Mr. Wilton, of West Lavington, and which was kindly lent to the Author for exhibition at the jubilee. He remained a Wesleyan to his death; of this he would sometimes boast, saying, "I am a Wesleyan to my back-bone;" and he never quitted the house where he was born until death.

SECTION IV.

His early efforts—Appearance before a Magistrate—Anecdotes—
Cornbury Mill—Death—Funeral—Inscription.

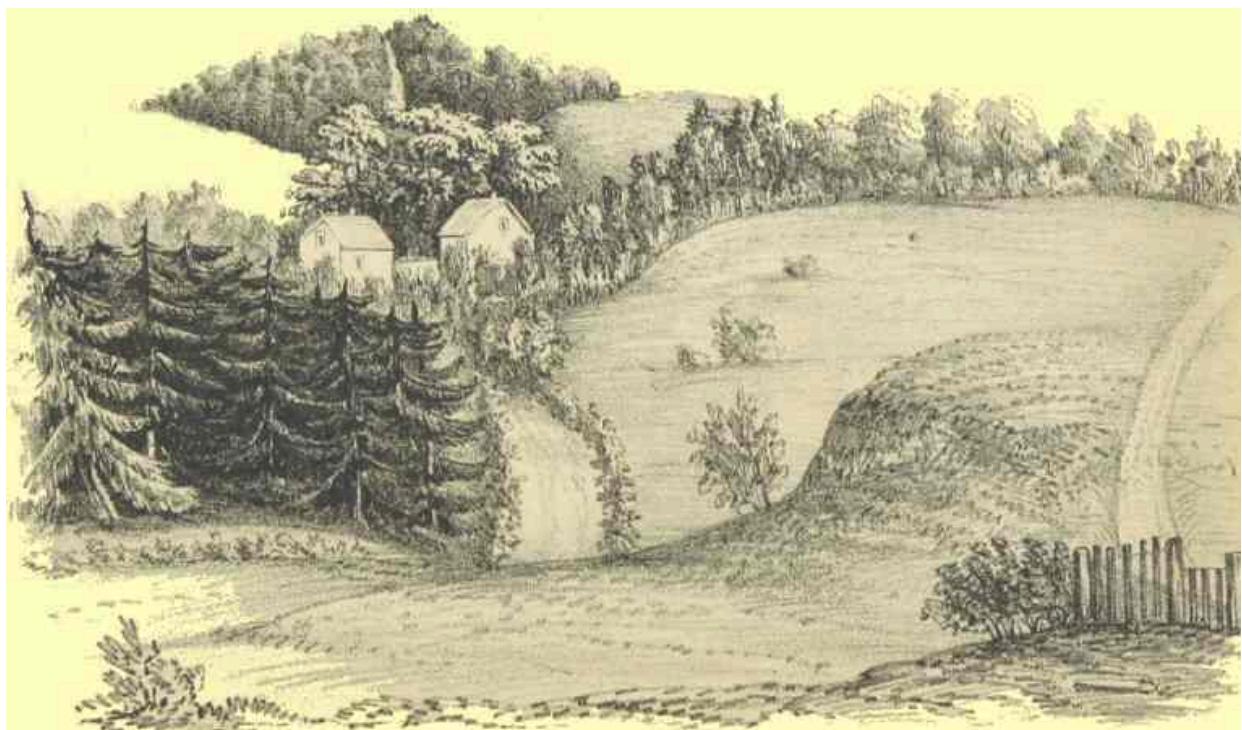
DENIED the spiritual enjoyments so abundant in the present day, which it is to be feared from their very abundance are slighted, he was accustomed to repair sometimes in the daytime, when he could leave his flock in the care of another, but especially in the evening after the toils and fatigues of the day, to Seend, probably where some of his own people might be found, and unite with them in devotional exercises, returning the same night, that so he might be ready for his daily duties, so strict was he in regard to the rights of others, and lest his good might be evil spoken of. He soon began to collect a few of his neighbours beneath his natal cot, at first at the time of his morning and evening orisons, and on the evening of the Sabbath, for the purpose of reading the Scriptures, singing and prayers, doubtless he would exhort them to seek the salvation of their souls, as appears to have been the case from his own confession in the instance that follows:—He was once summoned before a magistrate by one of the overseers of the parish, who, by his officious interference, sought to gain the approbation of those above him, upon the charge of not only allowing but himself preaching in his own house. Would he have been so active if he had carried on a course of evil and seduced others to sin? I trow not. When questioned on the subject by the bench, he replied, “May it please your worship to hear what I have to say. I think it my duty to pray with my family night and morning, and if opportunity permit, to read part of the Word of God to them. On Sunday mornings we rise an hour or two before I go to my sheep, that we may spend a little more time than on other days in the worship of God. Some few of my neighbours frequently come in and join us. We first sing a psalm or hymn, I then read a chapter or two of the bible, and sometimes I endeavour in my poor way to explain their meaning, we then conclude our Sabbath morning’s exercise with prayer to God. As for preaching, I never attempt any such

thing, but leave it to those who are called to preach.” The justice, who was a clergyman, reproved the persecutor and accuser, and admonished him to go and follow so good an example.

On Littleton downs he erected a hut for his own and others’ accommodation when the weather was bad; (this was blown down in a violent hurricane of wind, but was afterward rebuilt of firmer material, viz., brick, and made more convenient by his friend, Dr. Stonehouse). Beneath its roof, when the flocks were placed in safety, he would collect the shepherds and shepherdesses (for there were several at that time owing to the deficiency of male persons to do the work), and read to them from the Bible, or rather commentary, now in the possession of Mrs. Bartlett, of Cheverill, and after talking with them would engage in prayer. One now living (1855), then young, has stated that no one knew where he put the bible after reading, as she with others often searched but could never find it. He would sharply reprove the idle and careless, and then encourage them to diligence in some way or other, saying, “we cannot expect young ones to be old ones, I was young myself once.”

Among the other efforts which he put forth for the good of those around him was the opening of an evening school, where he taught such as desired it to read and write. Finding his house too small to accommodate his increasing family, but especially for those who came to hear and be instructed, he obtained the one adjoining, which he chiefly devoted to this purpose. A gentleman by the name of Bartlett, frequently invited him to his house; he had a son, an infant, who engaged the shepherd’s particular attention; and it is remarked, when at Cheverill, he would never leave the house until he had knelt at the cradle of the babe and poured out his soul in earnest supplication for his eternal welfare. Upon the death of the shepherd, that child, risen to the state of youth, appropriated the money that had been given him and which he had suffered to accumulate, to the purchase of the family bible, still in the possession of his widow, and which the Author has seen; it was a commentary, doubtless published by Wesley at the commencement of his public career, soon after leaving college; the date is 1751. He also bought the sheep-bells and two pet lambs, the last he ever kept, which was a privilege allowed by flock-masters to their shepherds. A view of the hallowed spot where this good man abode, and where stood the cot within which he first drew his breath, may be obtained to peculiar advantage,

attended with great picturesque beauty (as if nature would do honour to his memory), from a field adjoining Ladywood, just beyond the grove which is approached through the churchyard; a spot of which a respectable gentleman, formerly occupying an important position in the Independent church of this place, was wont to speak in terms of the highest praise. “I can never pass this spot,” said he, “without stopping to admire its peculiar beauty.” Doubtless the eye, the inlet to the soul, was instrumental in producing associations of the most pleasing character bearing upon the man and events whose history we are now recording, and contemplating those probable results which time would develop.



It was a favourite saying of the shepherd's when any one was disposed to stint a child or children in food, “Cut your last loaf as cheerfully as the first, they are growing and want plenty of victuals, if God sends children he will send bread.”

Sometimes when his daily allowance of bread, for this was the staple of his food, became very dry and hard, he would put it into the pond where his flock watered as he passed to the fold, intending after he had finished to return and take it out. On one occasion, having made the deposit, his companion (his dog), influenced by the spirit that often governs his betters,

proved treacherous and false, slyly slinking behind he approached the place and appropriated the coveted morsel to satisfy his own selfish appetite, in obedience to the universal law, "Take care of Number One." Upon becoming acquainted with his loss, and to him it was likely to prove a great privation, as the probability was he must go without food all day, he made his case known to his companions, one of whom, Mary Shore (who was under him for several years), pressed him to accept of hers, as she should not want it, having brought a double portion that day and already eaten sufficient: upon her repeated assurance to this fact he took it, pleasantly remarking, "Never mind, the dog, poor fellow, was hungry, and dogs want food." Exposed as he was upon the downs to some of those awful manifestations of the Divine power in thunder and lightning, he was never known to exhibit the least fear or alarm as to himself; this did not arise from a stoical apathy or thoughtless hardihood, but a calm composure and preparedness of mind for the Divine will. He would say, "I am ready whenever it pleases God to call me, here or elsewhere, and I do not care where they bury me, they can bury me here if they like," alluding to the hut before mentioned, near which he was standing.

Although religion in humble garb is apt to meet with reproach and persecution, yet in the case of this lowly follower of the Saviour there appears a mysterious charm, an immortal Ægis thrown around him, by which he was shielded from the many and bitter sufferings that often surround the disciples of Christ, and which awakened towards him respect and affection, not only of his own immediate class, for some that knew him have testified he was a right-down good man and there is no David Saunders now, but also of his superiors far and wide; a circumstance which he appears to have improved to advantage, not to himself or his family, but for the good of others and the glory of God, as he said, "There is not a house in the parish in which I have not engaged in prayer," in which exercise he manifested a strong temperament, a blending of confidence and enthusiasm bordering upon simplicity. The following is an instance:—Prior to a journey to the neighbourhood of Bath, he was led to engage in prayer with his youngest daughter Sally, then near her time; after commending her to God, he prayed that the child might be a boy. Soon after he reached the place of his visit he received intelligence of the birth, and finding it was according to his wish he immediately retired to return thanks to God for answering his prayer. His mind was also tinctured with a belief in the supernatural. On one occasion

he had been to Seend; on returning, he passed near to a house reputed to be haunted; hearing a noise his curiosity was awakened, and on approaching to reconnoitre, a voice (doubtless of some person engaged thereabouts) accosted him with “What doest thou here?” This he supposed to be a reproof from above, which led him immediately to quit the spot: and it is said he never after would go out of his direct road for anything.

Having relatives at Eastcote, he would sometimes walk over there on the Sabbath afternoon, calling upon the several cottagers in his way and invite them to come and hear the Word of God, devoting the time of his visit to a meeting similar to those he held at his own home. This place has continued to have services held on the Sabbath, and forms an out-station to Lavington, which is regularly visited alternately with Easterton, a hamlet noted for the indolent and vitiated character of the inhabitants, as far as it relates to the soul, if indeed they ever think about it.



In a short time similar meetings were held at Cornbury Mill, situated in Spring road, then in the occupation of Mr. John Gauntlett, the grandfather of the individual of that name now resident here, who with several other branches of the family are still identified with the cause of the Redeemer.

The humble shepherd devoted his efforts and energies both at home and here to form a spiritual fold. On the mornings of the Sabbath he would gather the sheep and lambs of Christ, such as under the influence of the Spirit hungered and thirsted after righteousness—feed them from the pasture of God’s Word—lead them to the fountains of still waters—direct and comfort the burdened and heavy laden with the precious promise of salvation. How long these continued is not exactly known. The honoured servant of the Lord, labouring under the increasing infirmities of age, especially lameness, probably the consequences of that disease he in early life suffered from, as also blindness, which for two or three years he experienced, he was unable to go far from home. Some friends who held him in high respect, residing at Wyke, near Bath, sent for him and desired him to pay them a visit. It was while here the messenger was sent to invite him to the home of his Heavenly Father, a release he had long anticipated from the toils of this wearisome world. On the night before his death he had engaged with the family in their devotions, and afterwards in his own room with unusual and extraordinary fervency. Sleeping with the son of his host he spent some time conversing on the things of God and eternity until his voice was silenced in sleep—a sleep from which he was not to awake till the Archangel’s trump shall tell the great day of the Lord draweth nigh. Blessed servant who was found watching; his last work on earth talking of heaven. His remains were removed to his own habitation at Littleton, and attended to their last resting-place by a vast concourse of spectators and friends. At his grave a request was presented to the officiating clergyman, the vicar, for permission to sing over his remains, he replied, “When I have done my part you may do as you like,” upon which, singing and prayer were engaged in on the sacred spot, for “precious in the sight of the Lord is the death of his saints,” so also is their dust purchased as the body is with the soul by the Redeemer.

The place where he was laid is near the north-east corner of West Lavington church, where a stone having a circular head, was erected to his memory by a subsequent vicar, the Rev. E. Caswell, from the proceeds of a small work containing letters and other pieces, the production of John Saunders, his grandson, for the benefit of his mother. Three of his sons, who formed part of a family of sixteen, served in the armies of their sovereign. The following is the inscription on the stone:—

ERECTED IN THE YEAR 1829.
TO THE MEMORY OF
DAVID SAUNDERS,
KNOWN THROUGH EVERY QUARTER OF THE GLOBE
UNDER THE APPELLATION OF
The Pious Shepherd of Salisbury Plain,
WHOSE LITTLE HISTORY HAS NOW BEEN READ WITH ADMIRATION
BY MULTITUDES OF CHRISTIANS
IN
EUROPE, ASIA, AFRICA, AND AMERICA.
HE WAS BURIED HERE BY HIS SONS SEPT. 9TH, 1796.
AGED 79.
ALSO IN MEMORY OF HIS WIFE,
LYDIA SAUNDERS,
BURIED NEAR THIS PLACE,
MAY 28TH, 1789. AGED 49.

Upon opening the adjoining grave lately (April, 1855) that of the shepherd's gave way, and laid bare some human bones, which, from their remarkable size (he being of large stature and muscular build) were supposed to be his; they were returned to their kindred earth. It was remarked by the Author's informant, "If we had lived in the days of shrines and relics, what a favourable opportunity would have been afforded, and what a popular subject this! but such times have passed away." The stone, which was in a decaying state, has, by the order of his grandsons, Messrs. J. and J. Chapman, been renovated.



It is much to be regretted that the humble abode where he first drew his breath, and where his voice was so often heard instructing his own family with others in the highest of all human learning, holiness of life, inciting them by his precept and example to breathe after heaven, a spot where began a reformation that has since pervaded the neighbourhood around, and doubtless had some influence in the Established Church, should, with the hut on the downs, like all mundane things, have suffered under the ravages of the iron tooth of time and covetous innovation (about two years since it was razed, and in its stead four brick tenements erected). But if the cot has disappeared, the site remains, and will be regarded with veneration for ages to come. It is on the top of a lane, known as Saunders's Lane, leading from Littleton to Russell Mill, just opposite the fields. May the relatives with the inhabitants of this locality be favoured to breathe the same hallowed Spirit as its long-gone tenant, and by drinking at the spiritual fountain that refreshed his soul realize those blessings he so largely enjoyed. The nearest of his descendants now living are the Messrs. Chapman before referred to, and Mrs. Holloway, their sister, of Littleton.

SECTION V.

Verbatim copy of two Original Letters—Poem to his Memory.

Littleton Wilts Feb 26

Dear Daughter

I Rec^d your kind and Welcom Letter Dated 23 and wase glad to hear of your Welfare I wase sorrey to hear of your loss of your master but are in hopes that your Loss will be his gain I Rec^d a Letter from Limehouse in y^e forepart of last Summer, which Letter I Ansrd Immediately:—I Rec^d a Letter from your Brother Jn^o from spit-head a board y^e Sibbley Transport Sep^r y^e 11:— which gave me a sorrey full account of his then present state that he was in ye 59 Ridg^{mt} of Foot Sergeant in captain poke Company and wase then waiting with 16000 men for ordors which they did Expect it would be for y^e west Indies but they could not tell and did Expect when they set sail never to see y^e Land no more—he wase verrey sorrowfull for his Dear Wife & 3 Children which he parted from 3 days before one of them was a Boy Born in y^e Isle of Iersey they wase set off for What-ley near Froom in Somersetshire—it pierceth my Heart with sorrow to think what they will do Amongst those strangers not having a Dish nor spoon or Bed to ley on I saw one of y^e Farmers of What-ley at y^e Devizes and he acquainted me they had a been thare a bout 1 weeck but he had not a seen them—They are a bout 20 miles from me I should have a gone to seen them my self but I wase not able being now under y^e Doct^{rs} hands in Cure for Sore leggs I has nothing to give them for Assistanc your Brother Benjamins Familie Incresseth a pace 2 days a go he had a 2nd daughter born which is 4 in [*a small piece of the letter is torn away*] and his Wife verrey Heavely afflicted all y^e last Summer so he hath nothing but his own labour to main-tain himself Wife & 4 children so he cannot assist—I rec^d a Letter from your Sister Jean about 3 months a go

from Ebley a near — Glouster and she acquainted me was Coock whare
thare wase master & mrs & 4 serv^{ts} 2 men & 2 maids but she was not weel
settled in her place because there was no Religion practized in y^e Familie—I
saw your Brother Iames & Joseph & Timothy Nov^r y^e 3 which ware West
Lavintons Feast Day I was Glad to see them look so well Timothy is grown
an Exceeding proper young youth and I hope he will be to my
satisfaction vi^z to Fear y^e Lord and serve him in his youth—I has none but
marey & David at home with me Sarah is married to Jonathan Chapⁿ & is
near child bearing may she have a good hower Maray cannot get aney thing
towards her maintainance because trading is so bad no spinning the poor
with us is almost perishing for want marey is willing to come to London if
she could get able and you could hire of a place of service you acquainted
me you thought you should not continue much Longer in your present
situation. But I would have you Enquire by Fervant Prayer of y^e Lord in
what state you may be most profitable to promote his Glory for now is y^e
Acceped time now is the Day of Salvation. Beware you do not let y^e
Flatterer deceive you to seek for Happiness oute of Christ, For I have a been
in y^e World near 68 years and I find nothing but but ye love of Christ with ye
Pardon of Sin will make me Happy here in this World I would not have you
put yourself to Expence of Comming Down at ye spring I should be glad to
see you but I Expect shortly to be called of y^e Stage of this Life & to follow
my Forefathers, let us pray for Each other that we may meet in y^e Upper and
better World to Sing our Lord's Praises for Ever & Ever So prays your
affectionate Father. If you let me know whare you are I will write to you so
long as I shall be able.

DAVED SAUNDERS.

Littleton Wells
Oct 12 1791

Dear Son and Daughters

This is to a Quaint you of ower Wellfare having this Oppertunity Ones more
to take pen in hand and to Wright a few Lines unto you hoping thay find you
all well and Striving Earnestly to Eanter in at the Straite Gate that Leadeth
unto Everlasting Life I Bare you much on my Mind be fore the throne of the

Lord's Grace Praying Earnestly that the Lord Would accomplish the Whole work of your Salvation in your Inmost Souls Enabling you to persevere in the way of Holiness and bring you at the last to his Heavenly Kingdom

I hope that you are all Well at Bedford and my Earnest praier for you is that you might be Saved from sin Hear by Belaving in the Lord Jesus Christ and Walking in Sincere Obedeament Love in his Truth and Commandments here so that in our Lord's Due and appointed time we may sing ower Lord's praises The Father and the mother and Childern in ower Blessed Saver's Kingdom whare parting shall be no more for Ever and Ever O my Dear Childern how do I long for your Salvation I know not what is the Thoughts of your Harts pray make Sure work by Examining of your Selves for De Lays are Dangerous Perhaps this may be the Last time of your Dear and Indulgent Fathers Counsels I Expects shortly I shall be Called home from Stage of this World Tharefore I Humbly Bagg of you as my Last Request Be ye Reconciled to God Let fervent praier be your only motive to Induce you to Love the Lord your God for what is all the World with out Gods Love for ower Blessed Lord and Saver saith What shall it profet a man if he gaine The whole World and Loose his own Soul or what shall he Give in Exchange of his sould Let me freely ask you what would be most desirable to you in Heaven my soul is Ready to anser and say to See the Face of my God whome my soul Loveth For it is Gods Presents makes Heaven and Jesus Christ who is the mediator and Interceader betwix my soul and my God O how do I Long to Walk in the Streets of the New Jeruslem but am detained by the Clogg of this Flish But I can truly say Blessed be the Name of the Lord With David whome Lord have I in Heven But thee and whome have I in Earth I do desier in Compaction of thee—Earths but a Sorrey Tent Pitched for a few friel Days A short Seased Tenament Heavens my song my Praise Oh happy Place when shall it be That I shall Reign with Christ in thee methinks my soul is now filled with transporting joy For the Apostle Saith to Romans Belivers that Eye has not seen nor Ear heard neither has it entered in to the Hart of man to Conserve what the Lord hath Laid up for those that Love him—Now my Dear Childern and you my son in pertickler make trile Let Jacobs God and your aged fathers God be your God Your father that are according to the Flish has made trile and can Withess for more than forty years he hath a bean a never failing God and he is the yesterdy to Day and for Ever I E centur all upon hem are you sick he is a kiend Phisician always redy to viset you are you Hungary he will feed you For Jesus Christ saith

Blessed are those that Hunger and thirst after Righteousness for they shall be filled—are you weary and heaven laden Jesus Christ saith Come unto me all ye that are weary and heavy laden with the Burthen of your Sins and I will give you Rest So we find he is Aurse and Good Physician files not in time nor Eternity Therefore I Leave you un to his Blessed Care to wash us all in that fountains of his most Precious Blood that was opened on Mount Calvary for sin and for uncleanness To wash us both you and me that soon we may from our sins be free which is the sincere Prayer of your Aged father

DAVID SAUNDERS

**TO THE MEMORY
OF
DAVID SAUNDERS.**

THY name be honoured, though the
Historic bard no mention make of thee
For deeds of prowess on the battle field;
Nor science nor philosophy a garland drop
Upon thy brow for vast discoveries in the fields of art;
Nor record hand thee down to latest age,
A politician, cunning, crafty, deeply skill'd
In schools of wily usage, who by tricks
And fraud, his own or country's weal extends;
Or by a lineal descent of princely worthiness
Didst occupy a throne, or place upon thy head
A jewell'd coronet. Thy ignoble birth, thy mean
Estate, thy humble occupation, thy poverty,
May perchance excite a laugh, a sneer,
A scorn; but thou shalt honoured be.
E'en now the young, the aged shall pronounce
Thee blest; and when the high and potent
Things of earth shall sink to dust,—thou!
Thou shalt shine bright like a star in the
Cerulean vault! and in the heavenly sphere
Shalt form a centre of intelligence; while

Around thee gather thousands yet unborn
To own thee parent and the consecrated
Means of all they hope or do enjoy.

Yes, honoured thou shalt be, for thou
Didst fear thy God and serve thy generation;
Thou hast done good service in the noblest
Cause,—hast fought the direst foe in thine
Own person; and in the hearts of others didst
Incite to deadliest hate, not against human
Kind, but against sin,—the fruitful source
Of mortal ills, of deep dishonour to the
God of heaven, the poignancy of sorrow's tear,
And the perpetual wailings of the lost.
The science, the philosophy acquired and
Taught by thee, was love to God, goodwill to
Man; while the great mystery brought forth to light
Was love incarnate, and the grace, the bliss
That follows from the Cross. The Cross received
By faith, a purifying principle within
The heart,—its light—its life. This was the policy
Much prized by thee; how to obtain eternal bliss:
That bliss thou'st gained, and though to frail
Morality, allied by common lot, its various
Ills (perverse inheritance) didst feel; yet
By the power of sov'reign grace, in thee so strongly
Shewn, to heaven's high only Lord thou art affianced;
And to thee a throne, a crown, a sceptre, and a robe
Belong,—nay, already are possessed, and ever will
Be thine; thou shalt still enjoy them when
Monarchs, kings, and lords, with all their
Royal pomp shall shrink to nothingness,
And envy those who poor were rich in faith
And heirs of God. Thus may e'en a shepherd
Gain a lasting true distinction.

We, the ingatherers of the precious seed
So long ago cast forth in faith, now honour thee

As God's own instrument, by which the awful
Gloom—spawn of satanic power that here fell
Thickly—was dispersed. The eyeball of the
Blind bid upward look on heaven's own orbs—
The Sun of Righteousness, whose heavenly light
Diffuses through the heart—the vital principle
Of life. The deaf to hear the music of the
Spheres,—nay, His voice that wakes the dead.
The stammering tongue, the tongue of blasphemy
And foul deceit, accustom'd to an oath,—to bless
His name, to speak His praise, or mercy seek
For sins brought forth to light; or blessings needed
To continue in the strait and narrow path.
The troubled heart to find the peace, the joy,
The hope, the balmy influence springing
From the life, the death, and exaltation
Of Him, the sinner's friend; and here
Each commence that song sung by
The ransomed choir of heaven.

SECTION VI.

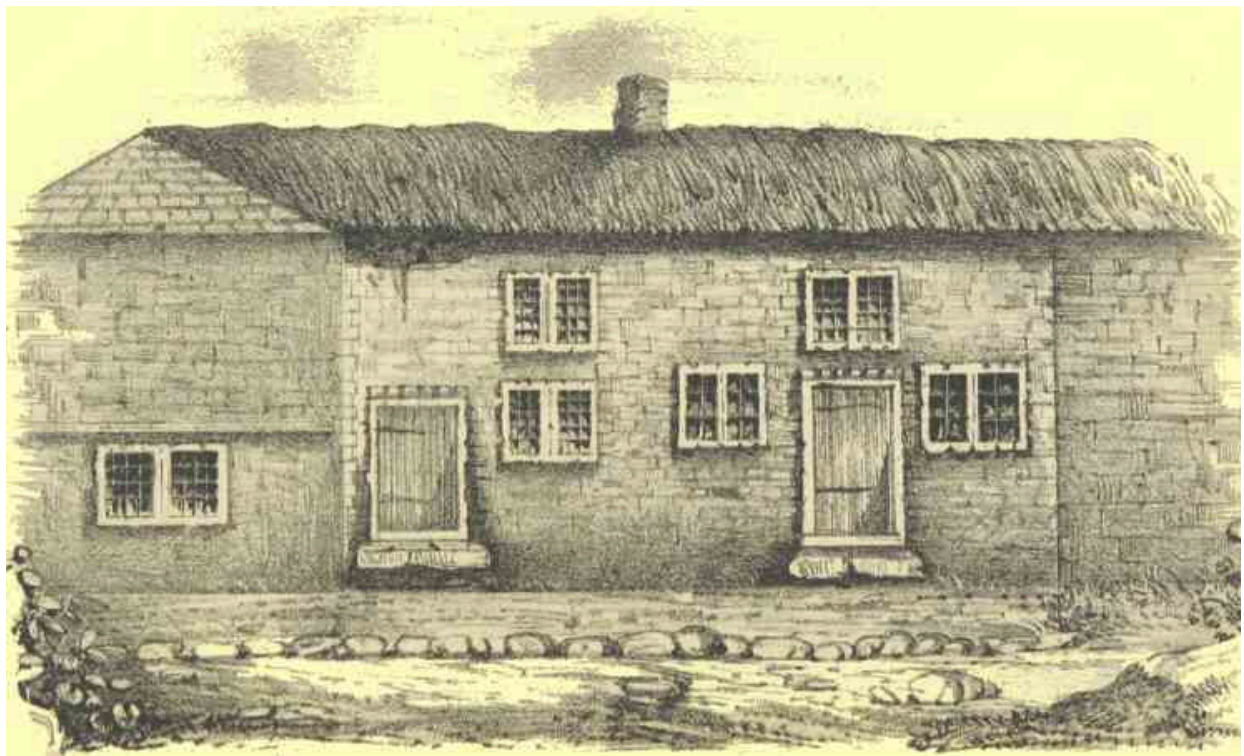
Immediate Results—Rev. H. GAUNTLETT—Cottage Services—
Persecution—Anecdotes.

OF the immediate results of the Shepherd's toil (which, owing to the erratic and wandering character of human existence, "for man continueth not in any stay," may be cast to the very ends of the earth), we gather this much: two of the sons of the owner of the mill were brought to the knowledge of the truth, and to feel the sanctifying power of religion, so that the scenes before described, and in which they had largely participated, were relinquished and abandoned, and a great interest felt in the growth and promotion of all that was "pure, lovely, and of good report." Of them it could be justly said, "Old things have passed away, behold all things are become new." It was mainly through their instrumentality a room in the mill was allowed for the meetings for reading and prayer on the Sabbath mornings. Another who probably from this humble teacher beneath this roof first heard the simple tale of the scenes of Calvary as revealed in the Gospel, of him it might be said, in the language of God to Cyrus, which will be manifest as we proceed, "I have called thee, though thou hast not known me." Having engaged, by his intelligent look and manner (which for one in his situation was considerable) the attention and notice of the lady at Clyffe Hall, Mrs. Vince, she advised him to devote his entire time and attention to study for the office of the public ministry; for this purpose he placed himself under the instruction of Dr. Stonehouse, at Cheverill (before referred to), and, after continuing there a suitable time, obtained ordination (the qualifications for which were not so high as at the present time), he became curate at Imber and Tilshead. On one or two occasions he preached in the church of this place. His discourses, though not evangelical, were much superior in quality to that usually afforded, and excited considerable attention: this may in some measure be accounted for by the spirit of inquiry that had resulted from the labours of the shepherd.

He afterwards was led to clearer views of Divine truth, which vastly enlarged his sphere of usefulness, and made him a great blessing, not only in his own parish, but in the neighbourhood around, and when we find that he frequently attended the meetings afterwards held in the cottages to be named, there cannot be a doubt but he was made a chosen vessel of mercy. Having on one of those days denominated Saint's days, probably being disengaged from personal duty, come over to Lavington to hear the vicar, it is remembered after the service visiting his father, then living, his mind was in a remarkably perturbed state, and, walking the room under great excitement, he remarked with solemn emphasis, "If you continue to hear such preaching as I have heard this morning, and are satisfied with it, you will all be lost. The Gospel must be introduced by some means or other." Nor did it rest in mere declamation, for he with others immediately devised measures for the accomplishment of the wish; he waited upon the Rev. R. Sloper, of Devizes, and entreated him to adopt means to introduce the truth. He afterwards removed to Reading. It was his lot to experience the truth of the Divine word, "He that will live godly must suffer persecution." When he left Tilshead the ringers, whether at the instigation of others or not is not certain, rang the bells to ring him out; and who does not know what that means? Well had it been for them to have pondered the kindred spirit manifested by the Jews when they exclaimed, "His blood be upon us and upon our children." He published a work of considerable acumen on the Revelations of St. John.

As a further confirmation of the good accomplished by these combined exertions, in which was associated a humble but pious individual of the name of Wastfield, who resided at Imber, and frequently came over and preached in the Market Place, on a stone that formerly stood at the corner of the butcher's shop, as did also some others whose hearts were stirred within them, when, like Paul at Athens, they saw the place given to idolatry of the most debasing character. Among these was a Mr. Williams, who was much persecuted, and obtained the cognomen of "Jehovah," from his frequent use of that term of the Almighty, and the "Dearly Beloved," from his affectionate entreaty when urging home upon his hearers the momentous concerns of the soul. From these labours of faith and love many were aroused to concern; and such "as had tasted that the Lord was gracious, and felt the powers of the world to come," made it their practice to repair regularly to Devizes on the Sabbath morning, taking with them their provisions for the day, that so they

might remain the afternoon services, “For the Word of God was precious in those days,” and of them it might literally as well as spiritually be said, “they went from strength (company) to strength,” each succeeding traveller or group overtaking the preceding one, until by their mutual blending (and like the disciples going to Emmaus, they talked of the things concerning their everlasting welfare by the way; and who can doubt but that their risen and exalted Lord would commune with them), until at length they appeared before God in Zion. But the true effects must be left for time to develop, and the full extent of the benefit can only be disclosed by the light of Eternity, when at the last great gathering of the precious fruits of the Sun it shall be found “this and that man were born here,” and when the righteous Lord, whose decisions will be according to truth, shall make up His jewels, and acknowledging the efforts and labours of His humblest servant, reward every man according to his work.



It was to be expected that these privileges, though so scanty, and which were highly prized, should produce in their minds an earnest and growing desire for the increase of the means of grace to themselves, and also for the benefit of those around them, especially of their own flesh and blood, as many would from family and other circumstances be prevented availing themselves of the public ordinances which they enjoyed. Now, in the

apostolic writings such a feeling is given as one criterion of a renewed state, "To do good unto all men, and especially those of the household of faith;" for them as yet nothing had been prepared; they were prompted to special exertion, and their first step was to obtain a room where an evening service in the week could be held, and when they could obtain the assistance of some minister from the neighbourhood, this was done, a cottage (chiefly through the instrumentality of the Rev. Mr. Gauntlett, before alluded to) situated in Parsonage Lane (now in the occupation of Hannah Love, a member of the Church) was obtained, William Smith was then the occupant: here, it is believed, a regular service was commenced. Such proceedings excited in the public mind warm and bitter persecution. "The enemies of all righteousness, the children of Belial," manifested open hostility, every method was devised to upset their proceedings. They injected into the room where they were assembled, through every available avenue, various substances of filth, disgusting and fœtid effluvium, as rotten eggs, stale wash, asafoetida, &c. In this honourable employment the exciseman stationed here was one of the most violent and bitter. The people dwelling next door, themselves hostile to religion, were open aiders and abettors, being prevailed upon by the gift of spirits and malt liquor to increase the annoyance by pouring these filthy accumulations down the chimney. Finding that the friends amid all these assaults displayed no disposition to retreat or yield, but an heroic determination in humble reliance on the Great Head of the Church to maintain their ground, and, if possible, make inroads upon the territory of the Prince of darkness, they proceeded a step further, blocking up the ventilation, and darkening the apertures for light, assailing them with all the known but indescribable sounds of discord, both vocal and instrumental, uttering the most disgusting and opprobrious epithets, and insulting them personally as they came to and fro. Still, no cry for quarter, no compromise was even whispered by the followers of the despised Redeemer, they not only remembered it was uttered by Him when on the earth, "If they persecute me they will also persecute you," and "these things will they do unto you because they know not the Father nor me," but they counted it an honour to share in His sufferings.

The storm, without losing any of its general character or being drawn off or diverted from the associated body, made itself felt in its individual power. The ties of family connexions, of friendship and acquaintance, and even of business transactions, were broken up; and where before the nod of

recognition, the hand of friendship, and the salute of relationship was given, now the sly averted look, the curled lip, the knitted brow, told plainly and unmistakeably the bitterness of spirit, the malevolence of soul dwelling within; but upon none did it beat with more violence and vehemence than the humble tenant of the house, who soon felt it in its own native malignity, and that, too, with the sanction and influence of parties moving in the so-called respectable walks of life, by which they sought to crush and ruin him. What pleasure does the carnal mind feel when, under the direct control of the god of this world, it vents its venom on those who, by their life, portray a virtue of which the other cannot boast? He was required either to discontinue the services in his house or to give up possession, supposing thus to cow the spirit of one whose daily maintenance depended on his honest toil. They had recourse to promises, persecutions, threats, and intimidation. He manifested the true spirit of Christian heroism, for although he never exhibited what some would term a decided proof of a renewed heart, being of a timid and retiring temperament, rather courting the secluded shade than the open blaze of publicity, which rendered the temptation more fierce and trying, yet his unimpeachable rectitude, his moral propriety, his constant and lively interest in the prosperity and progress of the cause, his steady adherence to it through the fiery ordeal, and his happy death, justify the conclusion that silently the sacred seed had vegetated; and ultimately he received the end of his faith, the salvation of the soul.

Alluding to the fact here stated, when visited in his last affliction and in the near views of eternity, he expressed himself thankful that he was not allowed to yield to the temptation, but was enabled to do as he had done, for with the Apostle "he conferred not with flesh and blood." Conscience dictated and he obeyed her voice, gave up the cottage regardless of ulterior consequences (for he had been told by his employer that he should visit with his heavy displeasure his persistence in such conduct), and having one of his own in White Street, which stood on the site of Mr. Hayward's surgery, he removed thither, carrying the ark of God with him, thus nobly consecrating his house to the service of religion. Was not this the spirit of the ancient believer who said, "As for me and my house we will serve the Lord"? What an example is here presented, a noble sacrifice worthy of all honour, which nothing but the conviction of the goodness of the cause in which he was embarked could enable him to fulfil. Verily the blessing he sought he was permitted to realize, for "God, who is not unrighteous to forget the work of faith and labour of love," has left it on record for all to the end of time, "Them that

honour me I will honour.” He was afterwards elected to the office of clerk and sexton of the chapel, which he filled with credit for several years; dying in a good old age in the year 1847.

The vicar being determined to suppress these irregular proceedings, as he denominated them, probably imagining as all clergymen do, they are the only authorised instructors of the people, used all his influence, and having secretly encouraged those low assaults previously recorded, but which to his chagrin had been unable to shake them from their purpose, now proceeded to open remonstrance. He placed a person to watch the arrival of the expected minister, who from some cause or other had been delayed; his anxiety to do what he thought God’s service, got the better of his patience, or perhaps fearing his emissary might fall under the evil influence of bad example, repaired thither himself. The person acting as precentor had commenced the service by singing, and was preparing to read the Scriptures, when he was stopped by the rev. gentleman (who had no fear of being cited into the Ecclesiastical court for brawling) and severely reprimanded for his conduct, and admonished to go home and not disturb the quiet of the place by such disorderly proceedings. By this time the minister had arrived, and the intruder, either alarmed at his antagonist, or, it is to be hoped, ashamed of his conduct, withdrew, and left the assembly to the enjoyment of their evening’s exercise. The following day he was waited upon by two Dissenting ministers from Devizes, and in his turn received reproof and admonition. Not at all relishing the interview, he made it as brief as possible, and gladly bowed them from under his roof, remarking to some one near, “If they preach as they talk, I do not wonder the people go to hear them.” Satisfied with one visit he never coveted or sought another, and though he did not approve, he would not again by his own overt acts bring himself into collision with them. Well had it been for him to have learned wisdom of the Jewish Sanhedrim, “Let these men alone, for if the work be of God ye cannot overthrow it, lest haply ye be found to fight against God.”

A blacksmith in White Street, a worshipper of the jolly god, Bacchus, on one occasion, after the indulgence of copious potations, entered the place where they were assembled, and endeavoured to interrupt the service. Having come in the extreme liberality and charity of his warm heart earnestly to expostulate with what he considered the deluded people, especially the minister, whom he evidently imagined to act under the impulse of sordid

motives, begging him not to disturb the peace of the village, saying, "If it is want that leads you so to act, here," said he, and accompanying the word with peculiar action, he drew from under his leathern apron or some capacious pocket a large piece of bacon, adding, "If you want something to eat, here is some for you." We can only hope that he may have been brought to see and know that "Man cannot live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God."

SECTION VII.

The encouragement from neighbouring Ministers—A Church formed—
First members—Sabbath schools—Chapel purchased—Opening sources
—Separation—First pastor—Enlargement, second and third pastors.

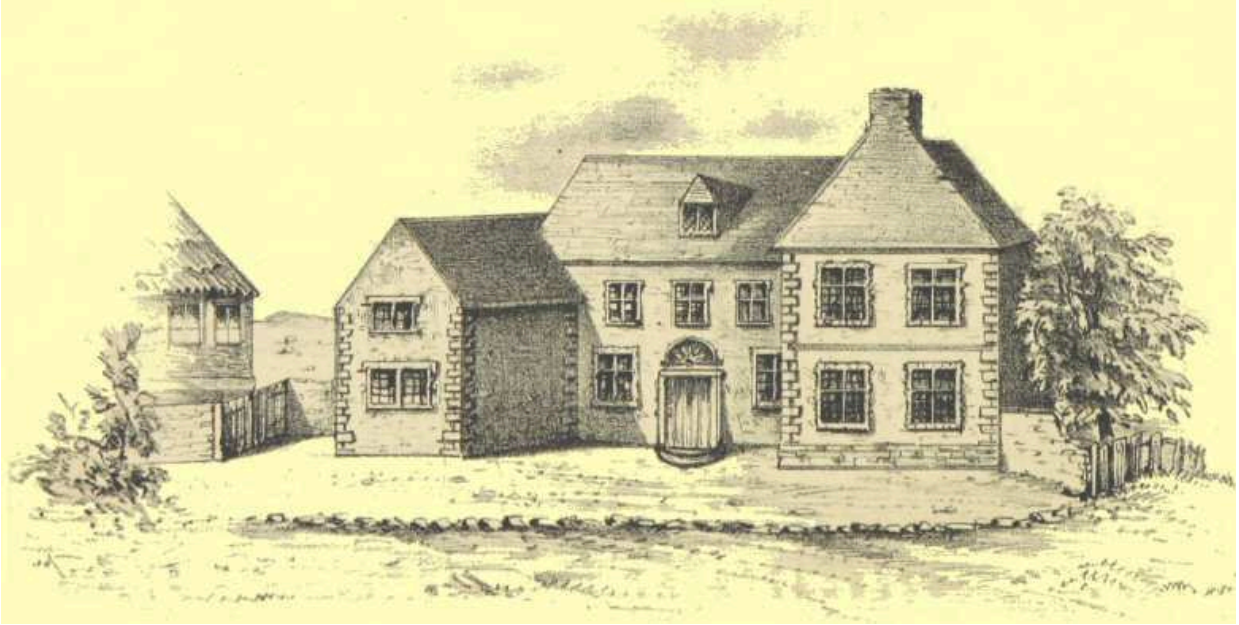
THIS little despised band of Christians, amid all the evil influences at work for their dispersion, were much encouraged by the continued success that attended them. Had the Established Church provided better spiritual food it is probable the growth of Dissent at best would have been very slow and weak; and had she, instead of the bitterness everywhere manifested, employed more conciliatory means, it would have tended materially to retard the progress of events, which the course pursued rather accelerated by producing conviction of error, and hence leading to a perusal of that volume which is and ever will be the only statute book of the court of hearers, to which duty they were specially and earnestly directed for a solution of all difficulties, a solver of all doubts, and the only safe guide in all practical matters. They were much encouraged and assisted by many of the ministers from the surrounding Churches. The Rev. Robert Sloper, of Devizes, who especially took the infant cause under his fostering wing, and hence during his ministry regarded it as part and parcel of his own particular charge,—a kind of out-station to the Church of that place. Mr. Honeywell, of Melksham, was also very kind to them, visiting and encouraging them as often as his duties at home would allow. Mr. Jackson, of Warminster, and Mr. Sibree, of Frome, were frequent visitors here. The latter would invariably have a service on the Monday morning early before he returned home; and it is believed was the means of doing much good. And there was the then youthful Jay, of Christian Malford, a name that will doubtless continue in the remembrance of the Christian Church for years to come. Some of his earliest pulpit productions were delivered here; he consequently ever after felt a deep interest in its progress and prosperity.

“So mightily grew the word of God and prevailed,” that about this time several persons of respectability were induced to attend; doubtless various motives were in operation—some were attracted by the juvenility of the preacher, Mr. Jay; others with the simple yet melting piety of Mr. Sibree; and a third class would desire to hear what this new doctrine or sect was which was everywhere spoken against; of many it will be remarked, they were in the way, and the Lord met them—“a timid, feeble, youthful hand may pull the string, but an Unseen One guideth the arrow,” brought to a saving knowledge of the truth; they “laid hold of the skirts of Him that was a Jew saying, we will go with you for God is with you,” and cast in their lot with his people.

An onward course was now imperative; the next step was to organize a Christian Church—a good sign when it springs not from the spirit of faction and wish to appear something but from a healthy action—a desire to keep the commands of Christ, and become local centres of influence, lights to diffuse the Gospel. Such we trust were the feelings that animated the first band here—a desire to promote their own individual well-being and the glory of God. Their tried and constant friend, Mr. Sloper, met them in conference, and making every proper inquiry, agreed to form them into a distinct body. Having laid before them the laws of Christ, the Great Head of the Church, by which they were to be governed, and to regulate their daily conduct, walk, and conversation, promising to preside over them whenever his duties at home would allow. The following persons then gave and received of each other the right hand of fellowship:—

Mr. RICHARD WARD.	Mr. JOSEPH WARD.
Mrs. WARD.	Mrs. ANN WARD.
Mr. WM. MOOR.	Mr. JOHN GAUNTLETT.
Mrs. MARY MOOR.	Mrs. MARY GAUNTLETT.
	Miss ANN GAUNTLETT.

The two last-named persons are the only ones remaining, the rest are, in the language of the Apostle, “fallen asleep in Christ.” Miss Ann Gauntlett is a member of the Church assembling at Argyle Chapel, Bath, lately under the pastoral care of the now sainted WILLIAM JAY: the other continues a member of the Church here.



In the year following, feeling their strength increase, “waxing stronger and stronger,” they proceeded to make provision for the young around them, fully entering into the spirit of that great truth which has since been so extensively carried out, viz., “that the future hope of the Christian Church must be the young,” they opened a school on the Sabbath for boys in the bakehouse of Mr. Gauntlett, the corner of Parsonage Lane, under the joint supervision of that gentleman and Mr. Joseph Ward, and one for girls at the old parsonage house, a little way up the lane, where Miss Saunders had a seminary for young ladies. This lady took the superintendence of that department: what were the numbers of the pupils and teachers there is now no record. These things continued until the purchase of the chapel, and the schools were removed thither, when Mr. Saunders (who with his sister about this time joined the Church) took the superintendency of the whole.

We cannot suffer an occasion like the present to pass without according to the memory of that gentleman the respect due to him for those efficient services he rendered. The energy of mind, the business-like habits, the sanctified talent, the spontaneous generosity, the unflinching rectitude, and the unwavering firmness which so strikingly formed his character, he brought to bear upon the prosperity not only of the school, which for forty years he presided over with unvarying regularity and constancy, never during that lengthened period been five minutes beyond his time, but the cause of the Redeemer generally, which in its various departments found in

him a warm supporter, and especially that part of it with which he was immediately connected as an office bearer. Many now risen to take part in the activities of life can bear testimony to the tender amenities, the affectionate solicitude, persevering and patient assiduity by which his instructions were characterised. We deeply deplore those events and circumstances which, under the mysterious arrangements of Divine Providence, have withdrawn the several members of his family from this locality, and thus denied the Church of one of his descendants upon whom the Paternal mantle might have fallen to supply his place, and hand down his name, zeal, piety, and energy to future generations. We trust that that family will continue to feel a deep and lasting interest in the prosperity of this our Zion.

From the continued accessions made and the decline of those prejudices and animosities which had so long vexed them from without, it became absolutely necessary that increased accommodation should be provided. Numerous difficulties at first presented themselves, every attempt to obtain suitable premises or a plot of ground eligible for the erection of a chapel was abortive. After waiting some time, the meeting-house belonging to the Friends before referred to, situate at the east end of the town, was to be disposed of: such a favourable opening naturally created a wish to possess the long-desired boon. A correspondence upon the subject was opened, and after due deliberation and counsel it was determined to embrace the offer, and the property was delivered over in trust for the especial use and service of the Church and congregation, under the denomination of Independents, of the Pædo-baptist persuasion, subject to certain conditions as to the right of the Friends to its use occasionally if required. These documents, with subsequent ones, are now placed in the custody of the County Association, who have provided a safe repository for such papers. It was a square building built of rough stone, having brick quoins, and a brick front on one side abutting on the street, a narrow lane conducting to a cottage running at the back, the other side and front standing in the graveyard, enclosed with a stone wall; the admeasurement of which is 23 ft. by 39 ft., that of the building 33 ft. by 22 ft. Some considerable alteration was requisite to fit it for its intended purpose, a pulpit and desk being necessary; these having been accomplished, the place was opened by two public services; that in the morning by the Rev. Josiah Bull, of Newport Pagnell, and that in the evening by their warm friend, the Rev. William Jay, then settled at Bath. Most of the

neighbouring ministers attended and united with them in the joy of that auspicious event,—the possession of a sanctuary of their own. They still continued dependant on foreign aid for the supply of the pulpit until about the year 1806, when the question of a regular established pastorate was mooted, especially as their much and deservedly esteemed friend felt the infirmities of advancing age coming upon him, so as to require additional help at home. The Rev. R. Sloper was unable to give them that assistance so desirable. This subject was one calculated to produce disunion, and painful as it is to contemplate, yet justice requires it should be told,—sad proof of the imperfection of human nature, even under the professed sanctifying power of the Gospel, the truth so long foretold by the Apostle became exemplified, “Whereas there are among you divisions, and strifes, and contentions. For while one of you saith, I am of Paul, and another, I of Apollos, and I of Cephas, and I of Christ, are ye not carnal?”—it ultimated in open rupture and separation, not only of the Church and congregation, but also of the Sabbath school, under Mr. Christopher Garrett, who withdrew, he and his followers, to a cottage situated in the lane near the weighing engine. A barn which stood near was afterwards pulled down, and the cottage enlarged to the size of the present building, from that time known as the lower chapel. The separatists have continued a distinct body of close communionists holding Baptist principles, from whom have since seceded the other body assembling in the new chapel in White Street, erected by Miss Husband.

In the year 1809, the portion of the Church that remained at what was then denominated the Upper Meeting, still desirous of a settled minister, chose Mr. Richard Ward, one of their number, and called him to the sacred office of pastor. Considering it desirable to his standing among the ministers, they proceeded to a public designation of him, and invited the pastors of neighbouring Churches to unite with them and recognise the mutual engagement. The usual and varied services were gone through embodying the profession of faith, the principles of Dissent, the nature of the Gospel Church, the imposition of hands, and the charge to the minister elect, with advice to the Church, in which various parties were engaged. He continued to labour among them with great acceptance until the year 1818, when the infirmities of age coming upon him, he relinquished his office. The attendance was much increased under his ministry, and several were added to the Church. It was during this period an addition was made of a gallery,

which was soon filled, and an enlargement of the building rendered necessary; this was accomplished to the extent of 20 ft., its now present dimensions, rendering it capable of accommodating about 500 persons. By these alterations a heavy debt was incurred, and remained a burden until the time of the Rev. T. Sturgess, in the year 1829. Mr. Ward lived several years after his resignation, and died in 1839, full of years and faith; he was interred in the burying ground adjoining, nearly opposite the lower door.



He was followed by the Rev. Mr. Slade, a young man who was educated for the ministry at the Dissenting College at Newport Pagnell, under the Rev. Josiah Bull; and in the year 1818 was ordained according to the usual manner among the Churches of the denomination, but only continued with them till when, from an inability to please some who were fastidious, he resigned, and removed to Corsham, where he has continued ever since with comfort and honour to himself and advantage to the people of his charge. May he long continue, be made an increasing blessing, and with them richly enjoy the benediction of the Great Head of the Church.

In the following year the Rev. John Guard, then supplying Portland Chapel, Bath (a new Independent interest which it was attempted to raise to meet the wants of the extensive population of that city, but from the want of encouragement in certain quarters failed) was, from the recommendation and with the advice of the Rev. Wm. Jay, invited as a supply and, being approved of, he was requested to accept the vacant pastorate: he entered upon it in the

year and continued to fill it till 1827, being constrained through the occurrence of some trying and unpleasant circumstances to relinquish his charge. Although he passed through the ordeal unscathed and with a clear conscience, yet he was much bowed down in his spirit, and felt his soul keenly sensitive, deeply lacerated. From hence he removed to Wickwar, in Gloucestershire, where he remained a few years, then went into Hampshire, where the cause being in a very low and unpromising state, and there appearing but very little prospect of its reviving, he did not remain long, but removed to Mavagessy, in Cornwall. How long he continued here is not exactly known. The next account of him is, that he returned to Overton, in Hampshire, and soon after terminated his trying pilgrimage.

The removal of this servant of the Most High had an injurious effect upon the cause. The circumstances alluded to produced a great convulsion; the Church became divided, part spake one thing and part another, these bitter waters of strife ended in a temporary separation, and those who left occupied a room near the weighing engine. The Rev. Thos. Williams, who about twenty years before had visited the town and preached in the Market Place, then residing in London, was visited by an influential member of that party, with whom he had previously become acquainted, invited to come down, and settle among them, which he did, although he afterwards much regretted that step, being, as he said, misled in the representations made to him as to the state of affairs. The pulpit at the chapel being filled by casual supplies and some of the resident friends, after about six months the breach was healed, and the two parties re-united, when Mr. Williams became the pastor of the whole body. Unhappily the calm was of a treacherous character, and the sky soon put on a very portentous and ominous appearance. The echo of discord broke upon the ear, and instead of the sweets of harmony and heavenly fellowship, a union of purpose and aim, the unhallowed conflict and strife of party domination, so uncongenial to increase of grace, became apparent; the good man's peace of mind was destroyed, and his usefulness impaired. After remaining a little more than a year, he closed his engagements with them, and withdrew to the lower chapel. He died in the year 1835, and was buried in the ground belonging to that place. A tablet was erected within the chapel to his memory.

SECTION VIII.

Cross-roads chapel—Ebenezer chapel—Fourth pastor—Chancery suit—Debt paid—Fifth, sixth, seventh, and eighth pastors—Improvements—Jubilee.

IT was about this time and in some measure owing to the above proceedings that the chapel at Littleton (known as the Cross-roads meeting) was erected upon the site of a cottage and grounds purchased for that purpose, which was put in trust for the use of the Independents, and though never actually attached to the cause at Market Lavington, yet mainly dependant upon the friends of that place and occasionally supplied by the minister, its chief reliance is upon lay agency. A proposal was made to take it under the direction of the church here (in 1854), as it was thought likely to promote its success, but as opposition was made thereto by one of the trustees, the attempt was relinquished, and they are left to their own resources.

From this, in the year 1839, a party seceded and formed themselves into a distinct body embracing Baptist views, and built Ebenezer chapel upon ground given by the Earl of Radnor. They have never been able to maintain a minister, but are dependant upon lay agency.

In the year 1829, an invitation was sent to the Rev. Thomas Sturgess, then settled at Melksham, requesting him to supply the pulpit at Lavington; at the termination of his probationary visit, he was requested to settle over them. He complied and took up his abode among them. Alas! how varied are the forms of evil, and how diverse are the phases in which it can appear; just as are the dispositions of the human mind so will there be found an adaptation in error, in perfect accordance with the nature of the reptile so fitly chosen as an emblem of the author of all evil, “The serpent,” as one of our poets has expressed it, “takes a thousand forms to cheat our soul to death,” compression or dilation, the assumption of any device or colour, just as suits his purpose, so that the progress of truth be impeded. We have before noted

how one after another of the servants of Christ have been constrained, by sinful perversity of their people, with wounded hearts and streaming eyes, to vacate their post; but now the scene somewhat changes, and the cause is to be assailed in a more vulnerable point. Ruin hovers over it, and how deliverance is to be obtained or from what quarter it is to come is a mystery. The debt arising from the enlargement in the time of the first pastor, and which had been suffered to continue, presses upon them, and assumes the form of a Chancery law suit: the property is attached, and the people are quite inadequate to combat it; but as all who are acquainted with law well know that as far as the defendant is concerned, it admits of no delay, but if allowed, like a leech, will glut itself with the very vitals of life. The people put forth their utmost efforts, and then made application to the Wilts Association of Independent or Congregational Churches for assistance. Having no funds available for this purpose at their disposal, they recommended the case to the Churches of Christ generally—the minister of the place travelling the county to solicit their aid. It was his privilege soon to realise the object which enabled him to discharge the debt by which the suit was stayed. He remained till 1834, when he removed to Marlborough, where he continued some time, then left for Sidmouth, and afterwards for Collumpton. In a few years he relinquished the stated ministry, and removed to the North of England. For the space of two years they remained without a shepherd, in a great measure arising from the diversity of temperament the human mind everywhere exhibits, and in no case more so than in matters of religion, especially in the democratic cast of the Dissenting Churches, which is an evil to be deplored, as too often affording to one individual the opportunity of governing a Church through the power of influence exerted over minds incompetent to a just discrimination of things; yet, when compared with the other evil resulting from the concentration of power in one individual, in the form of patronage is much to be preferred, as less likely to be injurious to truth. To the reflecting mind, the fact herein advanced will receive abundant confirmation in the diversity of creeds and professions with which the Christian world abounds, causing more animosity and heart-burning than any thing else, and from which very few Churches have escaped. During this interregnum their reliance was chiefly upon neighbouring ministers and what lay agency could be made available, which, unless judiciously employed, will of itself be productive of evil, by exalting some aspiring mind beyond his proper sphere.

In 1836, the Rev. John Young was recommended and at their invitation settled among them, but after about twelve months' residence, owing to some unpleasant affair of a personal nature, he deemed it advisable to retire. Recourse was then had to ministerial friends far and near, and that for the space of about five years; during which they enjoyed comparative quietness and prosperity. In 1841, those who preferred a resident ministry to the dissipating mode of mere supplies (which, however pleasing to such as admire variety, is not the best for promoting true genuine piety and a steady progress in the path of holiness; nor is it calculated to foster some of the sweetest and tenderest of associations—those between pastor and people), made an effort to realize their wish; when the Rev. J. S. Gilbert was chosen to be their minister with very encouraging prospects; but the fairest day may have its clouds. A misunderstanding arose relative to his ordination; and although every means were used to overcome the difficulties—much as his friends regretted the issue, seeing he was not likely to be comfortable, they advised him to withdraw, and with great reluctance he complied. The managers, for by that name the officers were known, opened a correspondence with the Rev. C. P. Hobbs, of Highbury College; though at first he manifested a disinclination to accept the call to the pastorate, eventually he agreed, and was ordained in the year 1842. During his ministry the cause rose to a very respectable position, but the varying atmosphere became again overcast and agitated from a quarter unexpected and unlooked for. Mr. Hobbs's views of church polity which he publicly professed at his ordination underwent a complete revolution; he therefore resigned in the early part of 1849, and conformed to the Established Church: he settled at Liverpool, but has since removed to the neighbourhood of London; and our hope is he may be made an extensive and lasting blessing. At the close of the year the Rev. C. B. Holder took the charge and remained until 1853, when, from some unexplained cause, he followed in the wake of his predecessor; and after for a time vacillating between the Establishment and Dissent, as the fane of interest varied, he at last accepted the office of Scripture Reader under the Bishop of Manchester, with the promise of eventual ordination.

The secession of these successive pastors, after solemn averment of having well considered the opposite principles of Church government, and selecting that from conviction of its scriptural truthfulness, was very naturally calculated to shake and overturn the faith of many, and give cause for

rejoicing to their enemies. The removal and death of some of their warmest and best friends about the same time tended very much to depress the Church and engender a state of languor. But hopes are entertained that the tide has turned, the crisis passed, and an amendment commenced. The present number of members is fifty. It had been the wish of many of the friends for a considerable time past to improve the singing, and if possible to avoid those fruitful sources of evil which many a devout mind has had to deplore and too often caused discord, by the erection of an organ. The promising appearances which have arisen since the settlement of the present minister (this took place at the fall of the year 1853), seemed to afford a favourable opportunity for its accomplishment. A committee was accordingly formed for this express purpose; and after a general canvass so much encouragement was experienced, that terms were entered into for one every way suitable for the sum of £40. Steps were immediately taken for its erection, and it was opened in December of the same year, when sermons from Psalm xlvii. 7, were preached by the pastor. The ladies of the congregation exerted themselves to provide new cushions for the pulpit and desk, and curtains for the organ gallery and windows. About the same time a pupil of the minister's, by the productions of his pencil, not only gratified the friends with drawings of the interior and exterior of the chapel, but by the sale of these purchased a hot-air stove, which he presented to the Church.

On Good Friday, April 6th, 1855, a balance remaining as a debt for alterations necessary, and the period of a little over fifty years having elapsed from the first establishment of the Church, a jubilee tea-meeting was held, which was very numerous and respectably attended: a great many friends came from Devizes and the neighbourhood around. The place was tastefully decorated with evergreens for the occasion. At the back of the pulpit was placed a perpendicular rectangle, in the centre of which was suspended the quotation of Scripture, Heb. xiii. 7, 8. On either side of the pulpit were arches with similar inscriptions, taken from Ps. cxxii. 7, and Ps. lxxxiv., 1. In front of the pulpit was hung a drawing of the shepherd, on the frame of which was:—"The memory of the just is blessed," the date of his birth and death with his age. In front of the organ, was a double arch with single mottoes of "Fear God," "Honour the King." The pillars of the gallery having branches of laurel were surmounted with similar inscriptions of, —"Love the brotherhood," "Honour all men," "Unity, and dwell in love." About 200 sat down to tea at four o'clock; after ample justice had been done

to the abundant repast provided, a public meeting was held, when George W. Anstie, Esq., of Devizes, was invited to preside. The pastor read the history now given, which was received with marked approval; he also exhibited the pocket bible of the shepherd and two manuscript letters lent for the occasion; after which several persons addressed the meeting.

CONCLUSION

MAY the Great Head of the Church, whose gracious Providence has so long watched over this interest, and through the fires of persecution—the troublous waters of discord—the agitation of envy and prejudice—brought it to its present position, vouchsafe His high and holy benediction, that Pastor and People in all their works of faith and labours of love may combine in the unity of the Spirit a holy brotherhood, contend not for Diotrephian supremacy, but for the “faith once delivered to the saints,” and aim to perpetuate the cause of the Redeemer, whose beginning though small has in its progress received marks of His divine hand, that generations yet to come, while they do honour to the memory of the Pious Shepherd of Salisbury Plain, may be folded by each under pastor, and at last owned by him the great Shepherd of the Sheep, when each local society of believers shall, by the powerful and purifying influence of “the Truth,” lose each minor peculiarity which now marks them, and generate a spirit of separation, unite in one universal, redeemed, and glorified Church, to place upon the head of their adored Redeemer the diadem of many crowns, uniting in the hosanna of a happy universe, saying, “Thou art worthy, for Thou hast redeemed us to God by Thy blood. To Him be glory, honour, majesty, and power for ever.”

THE END.

FREDERICK A. BLAKE, Printer and Bookbinder, Salisbury.

FOOTNOTE.

[\[13\]](#) 1 Cor. i. 27–29.

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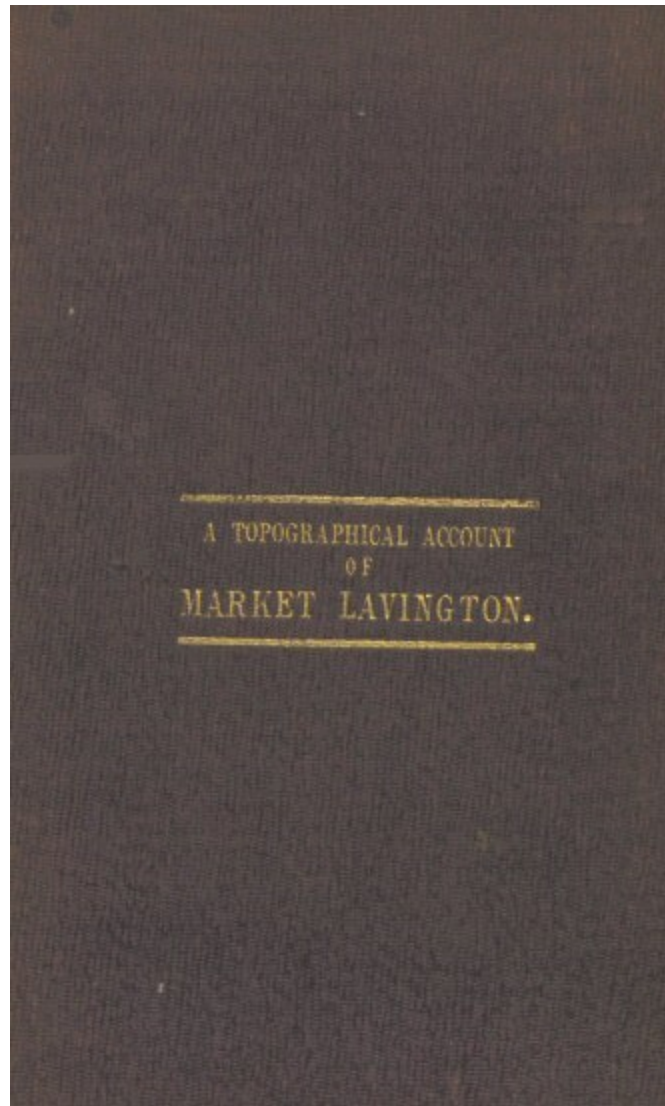
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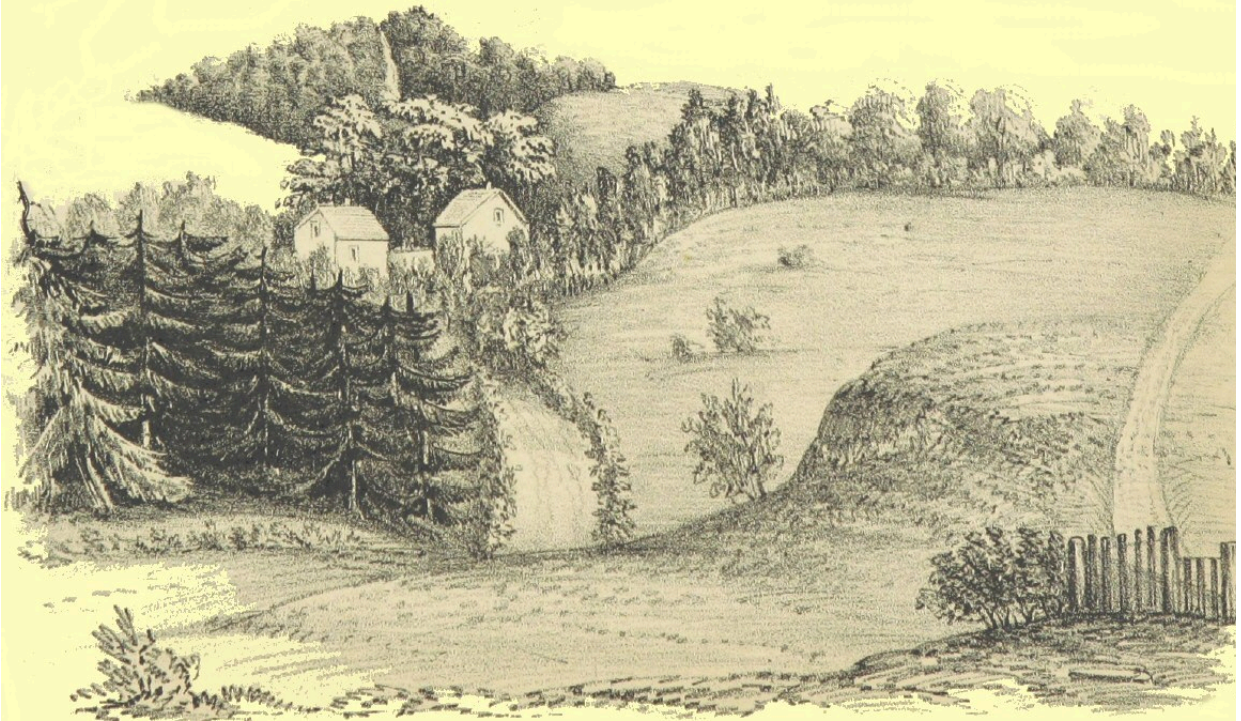
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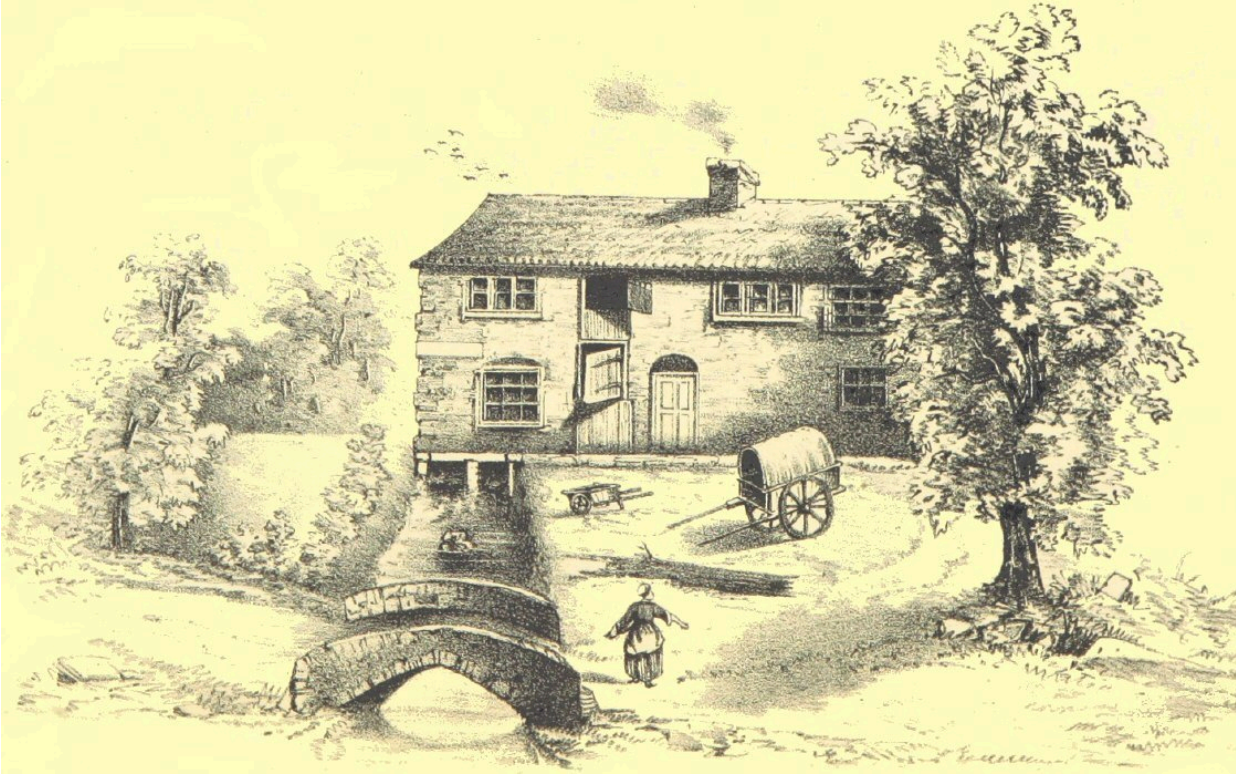
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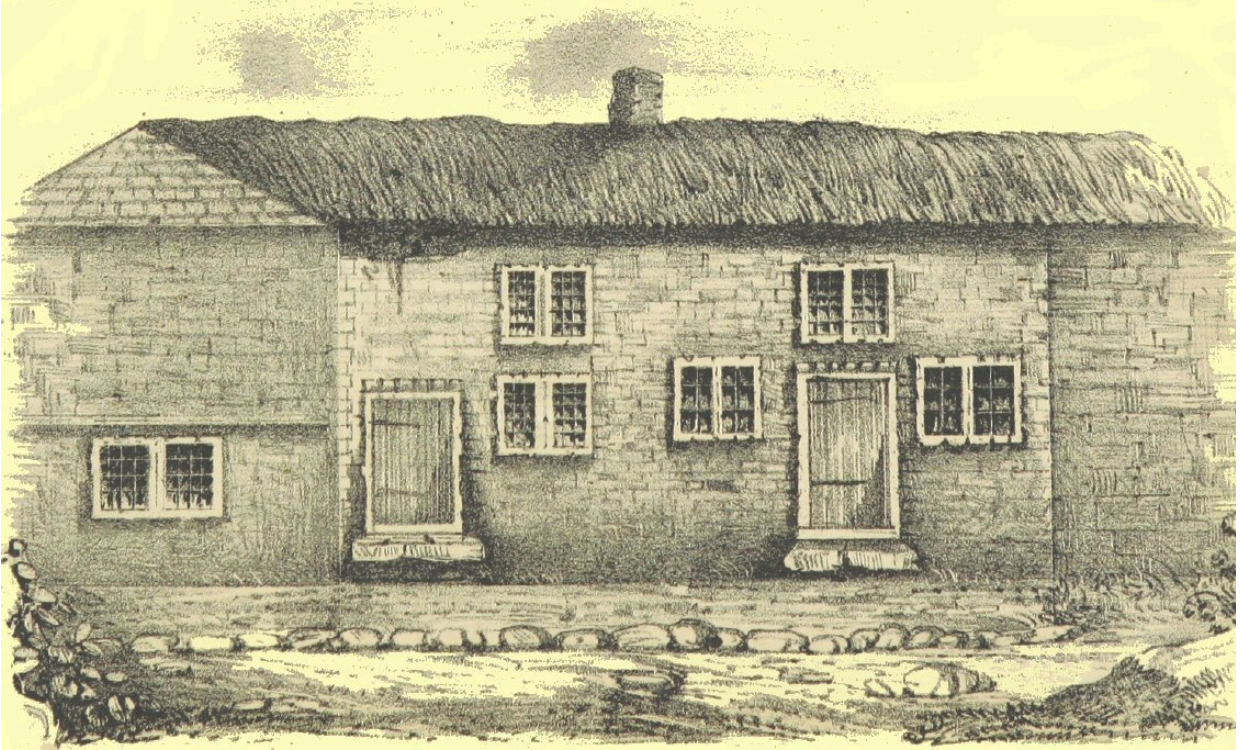
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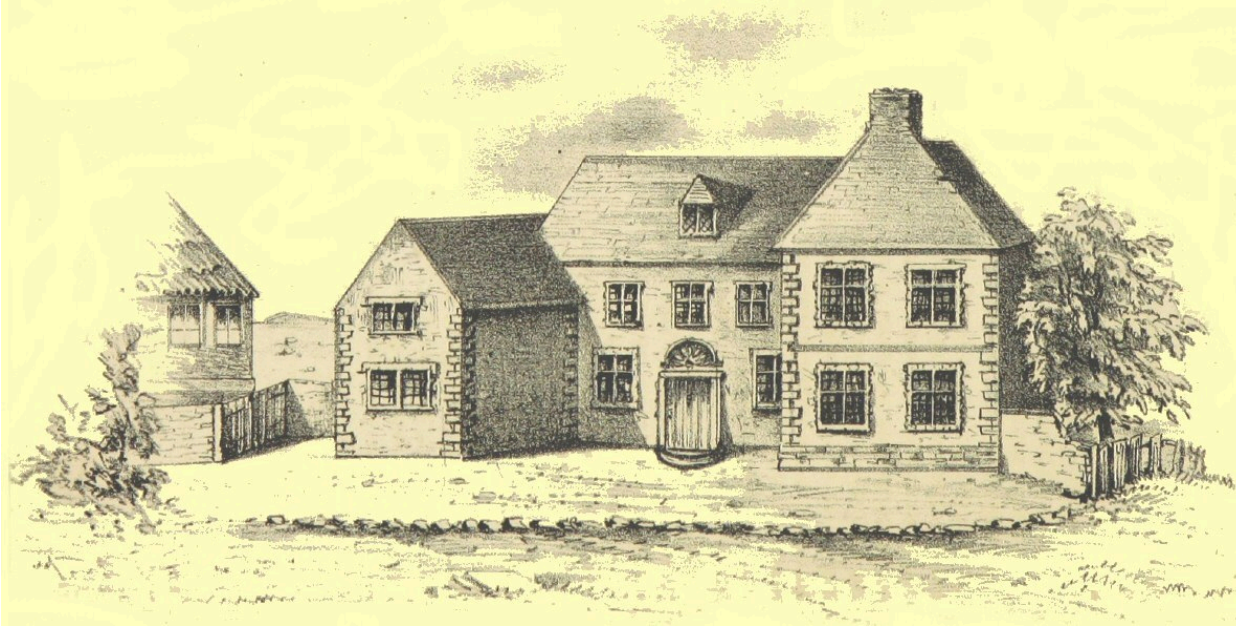
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